THE CONTROVERSY

NOV. 2021: Starlink takes pre-orders before securing a licence. The government asks Indians not to subscribe; the company later refunds over 5,000 bookings

OCT. 2024: India opts for administrative allocation of satellite spectrum rather than an auction, aligning with Starlink's position instead of Jio's

MARCH 2025: Airtel and Jio sign separate agreements to distribute Starlink equipment and explore offering its services, subject to regulatory approvals



JUNE–SEPT. 2025: Starlink secures a telecom licence, space-sector approval and temporary spectrum for trials

OCT. 2025: Starlink is asked to provide further information before demonstrating security and technical compliance to law-enforcement agencies

OCT. 2026: Musk accuses unnamed "oligarchs" of blocking Starlink and asks whether Mukesh Ambani is the "real boss of India". The government rejects allegations of discrimination

INDIA'S TERMS



DATA SOVEREIGNTY
Route Indian traffic through domestic gateways; prevent overseas data mirroring, storage



LAWFUL INTERCEPTION
Provide monitoring facilities on Indian soil, ensure the government can restrict or switch off services during an emergency or conflict



REGULATORY COMPLIANCE
Concerns over Starlink terminals operating in unlicensed markets; foreign investment approval outstanding

usage charge of 5 per cent of adjusted gross revenue, reduced to 4 per cent for rural and remote areas, for a five-year period. The proposal still requires clearance from an inter-ministerial panel and the Union Cabinet.

THE SECURITY TEST

The government's concerns go beyond paperwork. Satellite networks operate across national borders and can be harder to control than conventional terrestrial systems. "Things have changed drastically across the world, especially after the Russia-Ukraine war," a top security official told INDIA TODAY, outlining the conditions New Delhi wants all satcom operators to meet. These include routing Indian traffic through earth-station gateways within the country and prohibiting data from being copied or decrypted abroad or mirrored to overseas servers.

Starlink's architecture presents a particular challenge, explains R. Sundaram, national convenor of the Swadeshi Jagran Manch. "It utilises laser links to transmit data directly between satellites before it reaches a ground station," he says. So the government is examining whether India's traffic could end up travelling through this satellite mesh, bypassing domestic gateways altogether. Each gateway requires its own security clearance. India has also sought assurances that Starlink would restrict or switch off service when ordered to do so during an emergency or conflict, even if the company faced competing demands from another jurisdiction.

Concerns over Starlink's use in jurisdictions where it lacks authorisation have surfaced in India and abroad. In December 2024, the army recovered what was described as a Starlink device alongside weapons in Manipur. Musk responded that Starlink's beams had "never been on" over India. More recently, reports of Starlink terminals operating in Iran, where the service is not licensed, have raised questions about the company's ability to detect and disable unauthorised connections.

Musk's political interventions in Europe have also drawn scrutiny, though there is no public evidence that they form part of India's security assessment. He endorsed Germany's far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) party and repeatedly attacked then-British PM Keir Starmer, who resigned in July amid mounting pressure within his party. For India, the immediate question is whether Starlink can be made to comply with Indian law, regardless of its owner's political views.

A MARKET WITH LIMITS

Even if Starlink clears the remaining hurdles, India may not be the easy commercial prize Musk imagines. In July 2025, Pemmasani said Starlink's initial offering would be capped at two million connections, with speeds of up to 200 Mbps. Reported pricing of around Rs 3,000 a month, plus a one-time equipment cost of about Rs 33,000, would place it well above entry-level Jio and Airtel home broadband plans, typically priced at Rs 500-1,000 a month.

For Musk, Starlink's strongest case lies in areas beyond the reliable reach of fibreoptic networks and mobile towers. The connectivity gap remains significant: Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) data for June 2026 put rural teledensity at 60.9 per cent, compared with 153.4 per cent in urban areas. Maharashtra, Gujarat and Meghalaya have signed letters of intent with Starlink to extend connectivity to remote and border areas. Starlink and Amazon also signed agreements with Indian very small aperture terminal (VSAT) operators, which provide satellite-based connectivity to businesses and government agencies.

The question, therefore, is not whether Starlink should compete in India, but whether it can extend connectivity across the country while meeting security safeguards that the government can enforce. ■